



RESTORATIONESSENTIALS

Factory-Correct Restoration Reference

1986 Buick Grand National Restoration Guide

Model Year 1986

Model	Buick Regal Grand National (WE2)
Platform	GM G-body, rear-wheel drive
Engine	3.8L LC2 SFI intercooled turbo V6 (235 hp)
Transmission	200-4R automatic overdrive, 3.42 axle
Notable	Intercooler's first year; 5,512 built

Every specification in this guide was checked against factory literature, marque references, period road tests, and documented survivor cars. Where sources disagree or the record is silent, this guide says so rather than guessing.

Published by RestorationEssentials

Inside This Guide

The chapter order follows the RestorationEssentials house standard: history first, then year-specific identity, then the technical chapters you will use at the car.



- **Chapter 1: Buick and the Turbo Regal Idea**
- **Chapter 2: What Makes 1986 Different**
- **Chapter 3: VIN and SPID-Label Decoding**
- **Chapter 4: The LC2: The Intercooler Arrives**
- **Chapter 5: Transmission: The 200-4R and the 3.42 Axle**
- **Chapter 6: Suspension, Brakes, Steering, and Wheels**
- **Chapter 7: Paint, Trim, and the Last Chrome**
- **Chapter 8: Production Numbers and Rarity**
- **Chapter 9: Rust-Prone Areas and Inspection Guide**
- **Chapter 10: Restoration Sequence for the 1986 Grand National**
- **Chapter 11: Engine Specifications at a Glance**
- **Chapter 12: Options and Factory Details**
- **Chapter 13: Buyer Inspection Checklist**
- **Chapter 14: Casting Numbers, Codes, and Date Codes**
- **Chapter 15: Clones and Conversions: Tells That Matter**
- **Chapter 16: Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources**
- **Chapter 17: Sources Consulted**
- **Chapter 18: Thank You**

Chapter 1 — Buick and the Turbo Regal Idea

The Grand National was born twice. The 1984 car brought the name back — 200 horsepower from a 'hot-air' turbo V6 with no intercooler, blowing straight into the intake. For 1986 Buick finished the thought: an intercooler and an improved plenum took the LC2 to 235 horsepower, and the Grand National went fully black, nearly chrome-free, a year before the famous production surge. The 1986 is therefore the connoisseur's compromise — the intercooled mechanical specification at barely a quarter of the 1987 volume. This guide restores it on its own terms.

Chapter 2 — What Makes 1986 Different

- **The intercooler:** new for 1986, with the revised plenum. Hot-air (1984–85) hardware does not belong on this car, and its presence is a story that needs paperwork.
- **Power:** 235 hp at 4,000 rpm, 330 lb-ft at 2,400 — the 1987 car adds 10 hp and 25 lb-ft; know which calibration year your engine carries.
- **Scarcity:** 5,512 Grand Nationals against 20,193 for 1987. The T-Type (1,921) and the two-tone WH1 (463) share the powertrain and could be ordered in colors; from 1986 the Grand National itself is black-only.
- **Not this car:** the 1986 LeSabre Grand National (112 built) is a front-wheel-drive, non-turbo namesake. It shares a badge and nothing else.



Chapter 3 — VIN and SPID-Label Decoding

The 17-character VIN follows the G-body pattern: country, manufacturer, division (4 = Buick), series, trim level, body, restraint, engine, check digit, year — **G** for 1986 — Pontiac, Michigan assembly, and the serial. The engine digit to find is **7**: the LC2 3.8 SFI intercooled turbo. And as on the 1987 car, the VIN proves a turbo Regal coupe, while the **WE2** option code on the SPID label under the trunk lid proves the Grand National. The SPID must carry the matching VIN. Photograph both before anything else — Chapter 14 returns to why.

Chapter 4 — The LC2: The Intercooler Arrives

The 3.8-liter (231 cu in) LC2 kept its 1984–85 foundation — sequential fuel injection, Garrett turbocharger, 8.0:1 compression — and gained the air-to-air intercooler and improved plenum that raised output to 235 horsepower and 330 lb-ft. Restoration doctrine is generation discipline: intercooler, ducting, and plumbing correct to 1986; hot-air components treated as foreign parts with a paperwork burden. Chip-based engine management is part of the originality record — performance calibrations belong in the car's file with their documentation.

Chapter 5 — Transmission: The 200-4R and the 3.42 Axle

The 200-4R four-speed automatic overdrive is the only transmission, behind a 3.42 rear axle (G80 limited-slip per the car's SPID). Record the transmission's identification before removal, and restore shift calibration to the documented specification — on a turbo car the shift points are part of the performance the factory sold.

Chapter 6 — Suspension, Brakes, Steering, and Wheels

The Grand National package brought the Gran Touring suspension and fast-ratio power steering; the T-Type and WH1 share the running gear with their own wheel and trim treatments. Wheels and tires are recorded against the SPID, not against photographs of other cars. Brakes follow the G-body disc/drum arrangement — booster vacuum discipline on a boosted engine is checked, not assumed.

Chapter 7 — Paint, Trim, and the Last Chrome

From 1986 the Grand National is black — lacquer code 19U (WA848) — with blacked-out trim; the T-Type kept the color chart, which is precisely how a 'GN in red' identifies itself as something else. The gray two-tone interior is the GN treatment. Factory lacquer is unavailable in original form today, so a repaint is a documented modern equivalent matched to the WA848 chip and recorded in the car's file.

Chapter 8 — Production Numbers and Rarity

1986 model	Built	Factory rating
Grand National	5,512	235 hp / 330 lb-ft
T-Type	1,921	235 hp / 330 lb-ft
WH1 (designer pkg)	463	235 hp / 330 lb-ft
LeSabre Grand National	112	140 hp (non-turbo FWD)

Figures follow the Turbo Regal Facts and Figures Book as published by the marque registry (gnttype.org). Context: 1985 built 2,102 Grand Nationals at 200 hp; 1987 built 20,193 at 245. The 1986 sits between them mechanically and far below the '87 in numbers.



Chapter 9 — Rust-Prone Areas and Inspection Guide

G-body rust, G-body places: rear frame rails, floor pans, door bottoms, rear quarters, trunk floor, body mounts. T-top cars add roof channels and pillar bases. Under the hood, heat-cycled turbo hardware hides corrosion behind its shields. Magnet, light, photographs, notes — before negotiation (Chapter 13).

Chapter 10 — Restoration Sequence for the 1986 Grand National

- **1. Document** — dash VIN, SPID label, engine and transmission identification, photographs as found.
- **2. Name the car honestly** — WE2 Grand National, T-Type, WH1, or turbo Regal. The SPID decides.
- **3. Preserve the label** — never paint over, peel, or 'duplicate' the trunk-lid SPID. Mask it and work around it.
- **4. Disassemble by system**; intercooler and ducting stored as matched sets; hot-air parts, if present, bagged separately and their presence noted.
- **5. Frame and metal**, then drivetrain to its 1986 calibration, paint to 19U/WA848 in a documented modern equivalent, trim to the SPID.
- **6. Verify against the SPID** at every step.

Chapter 11 — Engine Specifications at a Glance

Item	1986 LC2 (GN / T-Type / WH1)	1985 (for contrast)
Rating	235 hp @ 4,000	200 hp
Torque	330 lb-ft @ 2,400	300 lb-ft
Induction	Intercooled turbo, SFI	'Hot-air' turbo, SFI
Compression	8.0:1	8.0:1

Chapter 12 — Options and Factory Details

- CC1 hatch roof (T-tops); CF5 astroroof.
- Power windows, locks, and driver seat per the SPID list.
- K34 cruise control; U52 electronic instrumentation where fitted.
- G80 limited-slip differential (read it off the SPID, never assume).
- Blackout exterior trim — Grand National only; T-Type and WH1 carry their own documented treatments.

Chapter 13 — Buyer Inspection Checklist

- SPID label present and VIN-matching; WE2 found for a Grand National claim.
- VIN engine digit 7 (LC2) confirmed.
- Intercooler and 1986 ducting present; no hot-air hardware masquerading as original.
- Black 19U/WA848 on the SPID for a GN; a colored 'GN' is a T-Type or a repaint until paperwork says otherwise.
- GN calibration (235 hp tune) documented — chips and ECM changes disclosed.
- Rust map (Ch. 9) with photos, rear rails included.
- LeSabre Grand National never priced as a turbo Regal — different car entirely.



Chapter 14 — Casting Numbers, Codes, and Date Codes

Codes carry the identity: LC2 in the VIN and SPID, WE2 for the package, 19U/WA848 for the paint. Dates follow the flagship rule — castings and tags precede the build and sit close to it. The 1986-specific trap is generational: 1984–85 hot-air and 1987 GNX hardware both circulate in the parts market, and neither belongs on an unmolested 1986. Part numbers and dates, checked against the build, are how you keep them out.

Chapter 15 — Clones and Conversions: Tells That Matter

The clone math tempts everyone: a T-Type is mechanically the same car, and black paint is cheap. The defense is administrative — WE2 on a VIN-matching SPID, LC2 in the VIN, and the build paper. A honestly described T-Type is the same driving experience with its own following; an undocumented 'Grand National' is a story sold at a premium. Buy the codes, not the story.

Chapter 16 — Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources

No torque value is printed that cannot be traced to factory service literature. The discipline stands in its place: clean chased threads, lubrication as the manual specifies, the printed pattern in at least three steps, re-checks after the first heat cycle where called for — and the same respect for turbo-system clamps and hardware as for head bolts. Values come from the 1986 Buick service manual in Sources; record what you used.

A Note on Documentation

Turbo Regal identity lives on the SPID label and the dash plate, and both can be separated from the car by one careless trunk-lid swap or repaint. Photograph them first, transcribe the full RPO list into the car's file, and guard the originals through every stage of the work. The identity chapter sits third in this guide for a reason: on a car cloned as often as this one, the paperwork is not the end of the restoration — it is the beginning.

Keep the same discipline for changes. Period performance parts honestly installed are history; the same parts installed silently are questions. Write down what you alter, keep what you remove, and hand the next owner the same honesty you were owed.

Recommended for this restoration

Shop exact-fit supplies on Amazon

- 1986 Buick Regal factory service manual
- Buick 3.8 turbo V6 engine rebuild kit
- Buick Grand National restoration parts
- 1986 Buick Regal parts catalog

As an Amazon Associate, RestorationEssentials earns from qualifying purchases made through these links.



Sources Consulted

Every specification in this guide was checked against published references before printing. Where sources disagree, this guide says so in the text rather than picking a number silently. The references below are the backbone of the technical chapters:

- **Buick factory literature.** the 1986 Buick Regal service literature and dealer ordering information — authority for torque values, specifications, and RPO definitions
- **Turbo Regal Facts and Figures Book data.** production counts and ratings as published by the Turbo Regal registry (gnttype.org)
- **Hagerty valuation research.** Turbo Regal model history, the 1986 intercooler change, and GN production context
- **RPO and SPID documentation.** option-code definitions (WE2, LC2, WH1, 19U/WA848) as documented in marque technical references

A note on numbers. Factory literature, period road tests, and marque historians do not always agree — production totals, horsepower ratings, and paint codes all have documented conflicts. This guide uses the best-supported figure in each case and flags the conflict where one exists, so you can judge for yourself.



Thank You

Thank you for choosing this RestorationEssentials guide. Whether this is your first 1986 Buick Grand National or your fiftieth, you picked one of the great ones, and the fact that you are doing your homework before you turn a wrench puts you ahead of most of the field.

These cars survived because people like you refused to let them disappear. Every correct fastener, every properly decoded tag, every hour spent getting the details right keeps the history honest for the next owner and the next generation of enthusiasts.

The year the intercooler arrived — all of the mechanical story at a quarter of the production. Restore it as the hinge it is, and keep its paper as straight as its boost gauge.

If this guide helped your build, we would love to hear about it. Good luck with the restoration, and enjoy every mile.

— The RestorationEssentials Team